Handova

An initiative of **Ethical Bridge**

TRUST & SAFETY · POLICY AND PROCEDURE

# Anti-Harassment, Intimidation and Bullying Policy and Procedure

How we prevent and respond to harassment, bullying, intimidation and discrimination on Handova.

**Version 1.1** | Approved 9 November 2026
Handova, an initiative of Ethical Bridge LLC

Skills handed over.
Capability that stays.

DOCUMENT CONTROL

# About this document

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|---|---|
| DOCUMENT | Handova Anti-Harassment, Intimidation and Bullying Policy and Procedure |
| TYPE | Policy and procedure |
| OWNER | Julieta Castiñeira de Dios |
| APPROVED BY | Julieta Castiñeira de Dios, founder, for Ethical Bridge LLC |
| VERSION | 1.1 (version 1.0 approved on 20 October 2026) |
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| CHANGES IN THIS VERSION | Students included wherever the policy refers to professionals. |
| NEXT REVIEW | October 2027, or sooner when Handova has a team, after a serious incident or when the law changes |
| APPLIES TO | Professionals and students, organisations and their staff, and the Handova team |
| OPERATOR | Handova is an initiative of Ethical Bridge LLC, registered in Wyoming, USA |
| CONTACT | safeguarding@handova.org · hello@handova.org |
| LANGUAGE | English. Read it online at handova.org/#policies |

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### PROPORTIONATE TO OUR SIZE

Handova is in its early stage. Today one person, the founder, runs both Handova and Ethical Bridge. This is our **first version**: it sets out what we do now and who does it. We will expand it as Handova grows and builds a team with dedicated safeguarding and compliance roles. Until then:

- **The founder is the safeguarding lead.** Julieta Castiñeira de Dios receives reports, decides on protective action and keeps the records described here.
- **An independent contact** handles any concern about the founder, or that the founder is involved in, and covers urgent cases when the founder can't be reached for more than 48 hours. This is a trusted person outside Handova and Ethical Bridge: **to be confirmed soon**. They don't run Handova or investigate alone: they receive the concern, make sure it is handled fairly and get outside advice when needed.
- **We review this policy** at least once a year, as soon as Handova has a team, and after any serious incident.

### AT A GLANCE

- Harassment, sexual harassment, bullying, intimidation and discrimination are never acceptable on Handova, from anyone, online or off.
- This covers Messages, calls, email, other apps and social media, and continues after a contribution ends.
- We take power seriously. A professional's impact CV depends on the organisation's endorsement. An organisation depends on free help. Neither may use that to pressure the other.
- Retaliation through endorsements, hour approvals, private answers or questionnaires is a serious breach.
- You can deal with it yourself (end the conversation or the contribution) or tell us through **Report a concern** or safeguarding@handova.org. Reports made on Handova get an automatic acknowledgement with a reference; emails are acknowledged within 2 working days, the same day if someone may be at risk.
- We can act straight away to keep you safe: freeze a conversation, pause a contribution or suspend an account.
- Concerns about the founder go to the independent contact (**to be confirmed soon**).
- Sexual exploitation and abuse of the people organisations serve is covered by the Safeguarding Policy.

### WHO THIS APPLIES TO

- **Professionals and students** using Handova, from sign-up to after their last contribution. In this policy, “professionals” includes students.
- **Organisations**, including every staff member, volunteer or board member who takes part in a Handova contribution, whether or not they hold a Handova account.
- **The Handova team**: the founder, and in future any admin, contractor, volunteer or adviser acting for Handova or Ethical Bridge LLC.

It protects all of these people, including the Handova team when users harass them.

SECTION 01

## Our position

Handova only works if people trust each other enough to hand over skills. Everyone has the right to be treated with dignity, to raise a concern safely, and to a fair, timely and confidential response.

Handova will:

1. Prevent harassment through our agreements, need reviews, product design and guidance.
2. Treat every concern seriously and fairly, whoever is involved.
3. Protect anyone who raises a concern honestly, or helps us look into one, from retaliation.
4. Support people affected, including by releasing them from a contribution without penalty.

Culture, workload or urgency never excuse harassment.

Where an organisation's own policy, local law or this policy differ, the stricter rule applies.

SECTION 02

## What we mean

**Harassment.** Unwanted conduct related to a protected ground (section 3) that violates someone's dignity or creates an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment. A single incident can be harassment. It can be written, spoken, visual or physical, including messages, images, emojis, comments on calls and social media posts.

**Sexual harassment.** Unwanted conduct of a sexual nature with the same purpose or effect. Examples: sexual comments or jokes, questions about someone's private life, compliments on appearance that continue after they are unwelcome, requests to turn the camera on for no work reason, sending sexual images, repeated invitations to meet, and any request for sexual favours. Linking sex or a relationship to an endorsement, hours, an introduction or any other benefit is always sexual harassment and also sexual exploitation.

**Bullying.** Repeated inappropriate behaviour, direct or indirect, that undermines someone's dignity. Examples: belittling someone's work in front of colleagues, persistent hostile messages, deliberately excluding someone from calls. A single incident is not bullying, but we still act on it. Fair, respectful feedback, or ending a contribution with a reason, is not bullying.

**Intimidation and abuse of power.** Using status, access or influence to pressure, threaten or coerce someone, or to keep them silent. On Handova this includes:

- an organisation threatening a poor endorsement, or refusing to approve honest hours, unless the professional does unpaid extra work, works at unreasonable times or puts up with unwanted conduct;
- a professional threatening to withhold deliverables, publish confidential information or post negative reviews to get their way;
- a professional or student using their nationality, seniority, university or "international expert" status to belittle local staff or override local leadership;

- pressing for personal phone numbers, social media contact or meetings the other person has not agreed to;
- pressuring the Handova team to change a review, approval or report decision.

**Retaliation (victimisation).** Treating someone badly because they raised a concern, supported someone who did, or took part in a review. See section 5.

**Discrimination.** Treating someone less favourably, stereotyping or excluding them because of a protected ground, including in who is invited to a need or who is accepted.

SECTION 03

## Protected grounds

Handova works across many countries, so we use an international list drawn from the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, the main UN human rights treaties and ILO Conventions 111 and 190. No one may be harassed or discriminated against because of their actual or perceived:

- race, colour, ethnicity, descent, caste, Indigenous identity, national or social origin, or nationality;
- sex, gender, gender identity or expression, sex characteristics, or sexual orientation;
- pregnancy, maternity, marital, civil or family status, or caring responsibilities;
- age;
- disability or health status, including HIV status;
- religion or belief, including having none;
- political or other opinion;
- language or accent;
- migration, refugee or citizenship status;
- socio-economic status, class, property or birth;
- any other ground protected by the law that applies to the people involved.

SECTION 04

## Where this applies

- Handova Messages, needs, applications, profiles and endorsements.
- Video and phone calls, email, WhatsApp and other apps used for a contribution.
- Social media, LinkedIn and any public posts about people met through Handova.
- In person, if people choose to meet outside Handova.
- After a contribution ends, where the connection continues, for example through an endorsement or continued contact.

Messages on Handova cannot be edited or deleted. Keep screenshots or notes of anything that happens elsewhere.

SECTION 05

## Retaliation

Retaliation is a separate, serious breach, even if the original concern is not upheld. On Handova it includes:

- writing a negative or false endorsement, or withdrawing one, because someone raised a concern;
- refusing or delaying approval of honest hours;
- answering "No" to the private "would you welcome them again" question, or giving hostile questionnaire answers, to punish a reporter;
- ending a contribution, excluding someone from future needs, or filing a counter-report to discredit them;
- threats, online abuse or contacting someone's employer or community.

When a report is open, Handova may hold back an endorsement, a private answer or questionnaire answers involving the people concerned until we have looked at them. We never use a private answer against someone without first talking to both sides, as our privacy notice promises.

SECTION 06

## Harassment and the Safeguarding Policy

This policy covers how professionals, students, organisation staff and the Handova team treat each other.

Sexual exploitation and abuse of the people an organisation serves, and any concern about a child or adult at risk, follow the Handova Safeguarding Policy and Procedure. If sexual harassment between participants also involves exploitation, such as help exchanged for sex, both apply and the stricter steps are followed. If unsure, report anyway and we will route it.

Fraud, such as false hours or endorsements, follows the Fraud, Bribery and Corruption Policy and Procedure.

SECTION 07

## Roles

| WHO | WHAT THEY DO |
|---|---|
| Safeguarding lead: Julieta Castiñeira de Dios | Owns this policy. Receives, records and handles concerns. Decides on protective measures and outcomes, unless she is involved or conflicted. |
| Independent contact: **to be confirmed soon** | Handles concerns about the founder or where she is conflicted. Hears appeals. |
| Organisation's safeguarding focal point (named for each contribution) | Makes sure everyone from the organisation who takes part in the contribution follows this policy. Tells Handova about any concern within 24 hours. |
| Everyone | Treats others with respect. Speaks up or reports when it is safe to do so. Cooperates with any review and keeps it confidential. |

# Procedure

SECTION 08

## If something happens

**If someone is in immediate danger, contact local emergency services first.**

### Dealing with it yourself

You can often stop a problem early. You can:

- say clearly that the behaviour is unwelcome, if you feel safe doing so;
- leave a call at any time;
- stop replying and **end the contribution** from its page, giving a short reason (you do not have to explain more);
- ask Handova to freeze the conversation, so no new messages can be sent;
- tell Handova informally. We can speak to the other person, remind them of the agreement, or help end the contribution, without starting a formal review.

We keep a brief note. You can make a formal report at any time. Ending a contribution because of harassment never counts against you (section 10).

### Reporting to Handova

Use **Report a concern** on the profile, need, conversation or contribution, or email safeguarding@handova.org. Choose "Harassment or inappropriate behaviour" or the closest reason. If the concern is about the founder, write to the independent contact (**to be confirmed soon**) instead.

Share what you can: what happened, when, where (Messages, a call, another app), who was involved, any witnesses, and screenshots. You do not need proof. You can write in English, Spanish, Portuguese or French. We use translation tools where needed, with care for confidentiality.

Anyone can report, including witnesses and organisation staff without a Handova account. You can raise a concern anonymously from an email address that doesn't identify you, though we may be limited if we cannot ask follow-up questions.

SECTION 09

## What happens next

Today the safeguarding lead, Julieta Castiñeira de Dios, handles every concern herself. If she is involved, conflicted or the concern is about her, the independent contact (**to be confirmed soon**) takes her place in every step below.

1. **Acknowledge.** Reports made on Handova get an automatic acknowledgement with a reference. Emailed reports are acknowledged within 2 working days, the same day if someone may be at risk.
2. **Check risk and route.** She checks whether anyone is at immediate risk, whether the concern belongs under another policy (such as safeguarding or fraud), and whether it must be reported to the authorities. She asks

the person who reported what they want and involves them in decisions, unless a risk to others means she must act.

3. **Protect people.** Where needed, she freezes the conversation, pauses the contribution, hides a profile or takes down a need, holds back an endorsement or private answer (section 5), or suspends an account. This is not a finding of wrongdoing. She tells the people affected, unless that would put someone at risk, and keeps these measures under review.
4. **Look into it.** She tells the person concerned the substance of the allegation and lets them respond in writing or on a call, and suggest evidence or witnesses. She speaks to people separately. She reads a conversation only once it, or its contribution, has been reported, and may also look at the contribution record, hours, endorsement, screenshots and questionnaire answers relevant to the concern. For serious or complex cases, Handova may bring in an external adviser or investigator. She aims to finish within 20 working days and tells both sides if it will take longer.
5. **Decide and tell both sides.** She decides on the balance of probabilities whether the concern is upheld, partly upheld or not upheld, records her reasons, and tells both sides in writing, with the information they are entitled to while protecting others' privacy. Depending on the facts and severity, outcomes include:
    - no further action, or guidance and a reminder of the agreement;
    - a written warning;
    - ending a contribution, with any honestly approved hours kept for the professional;
    - removing an endorsement, or a private answer, that was obtained through pressure or written in retaliation, and noting this on the record;
    - restricting what someone can do on Handova, for example no new needs or applications for a period;
    - suspending or removing a professional or organisation from Handova;
    - telling the Ethical Bridge directory, or referring to the authorities, where the law or someone's safety requires it.
6. **Appeal.** Either side can appeal within 30 days by writing to the independent contact (**to be confirmed soon**), saying why: for example, an unfair process, new evidence or a disproportionate outcome. If the independent contact handled the original case, Handova may bring in an external adviser to hear the appeal. The appeal decision is final within Handova. It does not affect anyone's rights under the law.

Where Handova restricts or removes an account or content, we tell the person why and how to ask for a review. Where the law allows, we may share confirmed findings of sexual exploitation, abuse or harassment with organisations that ask, following the principles of the Misconduct Disclosure Scheme. We also look at what Handova could change, such as a need review step, guidance or a product feature.

Everyone involved is treated with respect, and no one is presumed to have done wrong until the facts are established.

We will expand this procedure as Handova grows.

SECTION 10

## Support

- Julieta Castiñeira de Dios, or the independent contact if the case is about her, keeps you updated.
- If you end a contribution because of harassment, it does not count against your activity, your honestly approved hours stay on record, and Handova can mark the contribution "Closed by Handova".

- Organisations can reopen the need with someone else.
- You can pause your profile or needs while a case is open.
- We can point you to support services where you live.

Handova does not provide counselling. Using this procedure does not remove anyone's right to go to the authorities or courts where they live.

SECTION 11

## Confidentiality and data

We share information only with people who need it to handle the case, and protect the reporter's identity as far as we can. In a two-person conversation the other side may guess who reported; we tell you before we act if that is likely. Everyone involved keeps the matter confidential, though anyone may get legal advice or contact a regulator.

Personal data is handled under our privacy notice and the GDPR, subject to lawful limits that protect reviews and other people. We never put personal, confidential, report, identity or safeguarding information into AI tools.

SECTION 12

## Records and retention

The safeguarding lead keeps case notes, evidence and outcomes in Handova's case records. Only the safeguarding lead can see them, and the independent contact for cases about the founder. Case records are kept for 6 years after the case closes, or longer if legal proceedings are ongoing or expected. Cases involving a child are kept until the child turns 25 or for 6 years after closure, whichever is later. Records are then deleted. We review them once a year.

Each year the founder writes a short anonymised summary of concerns, outcomes and lessons, kept on file and shared with the independent contact once named.

SECTION 13

## False or malicious reports

Please report what worries you. Nobody is penalised for a genuine concern, even if it is not upheld or some details are wrong. Knowingly making a false report, or reporting to discredit someone, is a breach and may lead to the outcomes in section 9. We decide this only after a review, never just because a concern was not upheld.

SECTION 14

## Prevention and review

- We review every need before it opens, watching for unclear scope or requests for personal contact.
- Professionals read "Working responsibly" and sign the agreement before they take part. The agreements set out expected conduct; first-call tips remind people of boundaries.
- We review this policy yearly, using the anonymised summary.

- **For the future:** as Handova grows, we will add training for the team and short briefings for professionals, students and organisations.

SECTION 15

## Law, standards and related documents

Ethical Bridge LLC is registered in Wyoming, USA, and is subject to US federal and Wyoming law. People take part from many countries, so we also follow the law that applies where they are, including the EU and UK GDPR for personal data. Where rules differ, we follow the one that gives people more protection. We report to the relevant authorities where the law requires it, or where someone is in immediate danger.

Standards: ILO Conventions 190 and 111, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, CEDAW, the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities, and the GDPR.

Related Handova documents: Safeguarding Policy and Procedure; Anti-Harassment, Intimidation and Bullying Policy and Procedure (this document); Code of Conduct; Data Protection Policy; Fraud, Bribery and Corruption Policy and Procedure; Whistleblowing Policy and Procedure; Independent Contact Role Note. Also the Handova agreements, Terms of use and Privacy notice.